

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

IN THE SADDLE BSP supremo Mayawati with her nephew and political heir Akash Anand. Reinstated as the party's national coordinator, he is now calling the shots

This decision followed Akash's controversial speech in Sitapur on April 28, where he used unparliamentary language against opponents, resulting in an FIR.

But the decision to sideline Akash backfired as it led to confusion among the party cadre. Consequently, a significant portion of the Dalit vote shifted towards the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) constituents Samajwadi Party and Congress, leaving the BSP without a single seat in UP. In fact, the BSP saw its vote share reduce to single digits for the first time in decades– just 9.4 per cent. According to a Lokniti-CSDS (Centre for the Study of Developing Societies) post-poll survey, the party retained only 44 per cent of the Jatav vote, its traditional voter base, down from 68 per cent in 2014, besides just 15 per cent of the non-Jatav Dalit vote as compared to 30 per cent a decade back. Dalits comprise about 20 per cent of the state's population, with Jatavs estimated to account for around 55 per cent of the community.

Mayawati now seems to be on a course correction. With Akash leading the charge and trying to bring the Dalit youth back into the party fold, the BSP supremo intends to contest the upcoming UP bypolls to all 10 vacant assembly seats. (The dates have yet to be announced.) On the other hand, Chandrashekhar's victory in Nagina has emboldened him to contest all seats in the high-stakes bypolls as well. "We have already developed our party cadre in every district. Now we will contest on all seats," the Bhim Army chief told INDIA TODAY, adding that the "trust shown in us" has given his confidence a big boost. Even as Chandrashekhar claims that he is not just a Dalit leader and represents people from all castes and religions in his constituency, there's no denying that he sees himself as the heir to Mayawati's and her mentor and BSP founder Kanshi Ram's legacy. The name of his political front–Azad Samaj Party (Kanshi Ram)–says it all. "After the 2022 assembly polls," he says, "the BSP's supporters started aligning with me. To take on the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), we need leaders with foresight. She [Mayawati] did a lot of work in her time, but now I want the ASP to complete her unfinished projects."

But with the SP-Congress combine making significant inroads into the Dalit vote bank, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav will not be willing to cede even an inch of the gained ground to the two young rivals. Akhilesh's 'PDA' strategy puts the 'D' (Dalit) in the middle, underlining the party's outreach beyond its old Muslim-Yadav base, denoted by 'P' for *pichhda* or backward and 'A' for *alpasankhyak* or minorities. This has paid dividends, with the INDIA bloc securing 56 per cent of the non-Jatav Dalit vote and 25 per cent of the Jatav vote, according to the Lokniti-CSDS post-poll survey. Traditionally seen as a party of Muslims and Yadavs, the SP, in fact, managed to win seven out of the 17 constituencies reserved for Scheduled Castes, up from a tally of zero in the last Lok Sabha election.

WHILE THE BSP TRIES TO WREST BACK ITS PRIMARY TURF FROM NEW CLAIMANTS LIKE CHANDRASHEKHAR OF THE BHIM ARMY, THE SP'S NEW 'PDA' PLANK COMES AS A FRESH CHALLENGE

Not just the BSP, even the BJP has been at the receiving end of Akhilesh's social engineering strategy, one that the ruling party had originally perfected by lassoing in the non-Jatav Dalits and non-Yadav OBCs. Amid this attitudinal shift among a crucial section of the electorate, the upcoming byelections will be a litmus test for the BSP–at least in the two reserved seats of Milkipur and Khair. ■

LIT VOTE



"The BSP is in a perpetual decline, for which they themselves are responsible. She [Mayawati] did a lot of work in her time, but now I want the ASP to complete her unfinished projects"

-CHANDRASHEKHAR

Azad Samaj Party (Kanshi Ram) chief & Nagina MP